Are Cleveland 311 Requests Closed On Time?

Arockia Robin Sebastin Leo · October 2026 · Data: City of Cleveland Open Data Portal, 311 Service Requests, Feb 28, 2024 to Oct 23, 2026 (188,406 requests) · Tools: SQL (SQLite), Python

Question

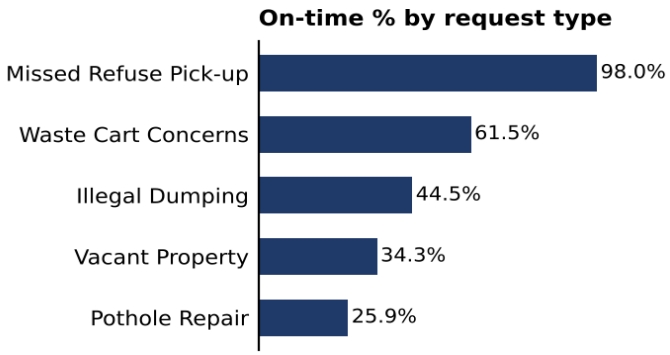
The Mayor's Strategic Plan lists **"% of 311 service requests closed on time"** as a City performance measure. The public 311 dashboard shows volume, status and location. Using the same open data, how often are requests closed by their target date, and where does that vary?

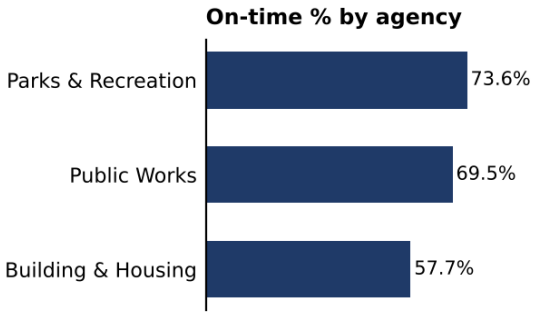
Method

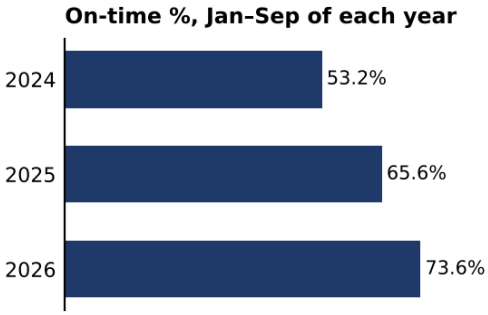
Loaded the CSV into SQLite and cleaned it in SQL (renamed columns, blanks to NULL, numeric types, US dates converted to ISO). Ran five validation checks, then calculated **on time = closed on or before the target date** for the 179,842 closed requests with a target date and valid timestamps.

Key findings

- **68.1%** of closed requests met their target date.
- **Improving:** Jan–Sep on-time rose from 53.2% (2024) to 65.6% (2025) to 73.6% (2026).
- **By agency:** Building & Housing is lowest at 57.7%, averaging 51.8 days to close against an average 22-day target window.
- **By request type,** the gap is widest: routine sanitation is near 100% (Missed Refuse Pick-up 98.0%), while Pothole Repair (25.9%) and Vacant Property (34.3%) are low.
- **By ward,** differences are small: 64.5% (Ward 8) to 72.1% (Ward 1).







Data quality

Check	Result	How handled
Duplicates	0 duplicate reference numbers	None needed
Status vs. closed date	Consistent for all 188,406 rows	None needed
Closed before requested	**915** rows, all Public Works (567) or Parks & Rec (348); 739 from inbound calls, about 2 hours apart	Excluded. Likely logged after the work was done; worth confirming with department data leads
No target date	3,660 rows	Excluded from on-time rate
No ward	429 rows	Excluded from ward results only
Open and past target	2,689 requests	Not in the rate (closed requests only); including them would lower it

Questions and next steps

- **Definition:** confirm how the official on-time measure treats open, overdue requests.
- **Targets:** review low on-time types (potholes, vacant property) for unrealistic targets versus capacity limits.
- **Logging:** work with Public Works and Parks & Recreation on timestamps for phone-in requests.
- **Reporting:** an on-time view could sit alongside the existing volume dashboard.

Limitations

- Public data only; the City's official method may differ.
- Target dates come from the source system and are not evaluated here.
- Recent months may shift as open requests close.

SQL and dashboard: github.com/[your-username]/cleveland-311-on-time